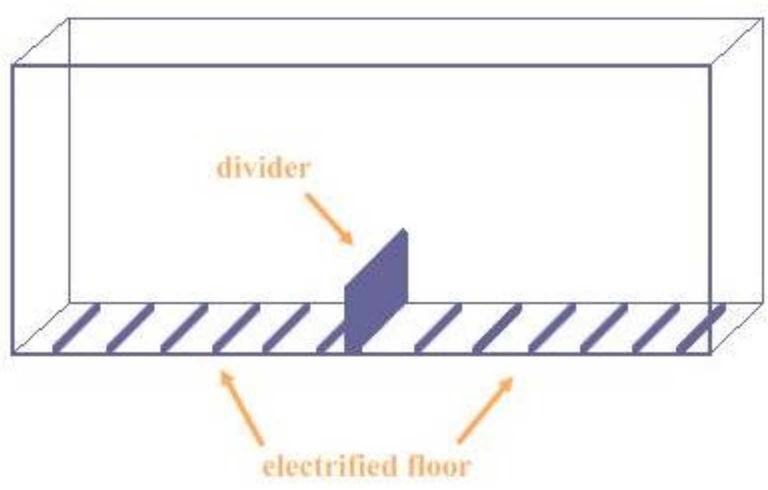
Case Study 15

Learned Helplessness

The phenomenon called *learned helplessness* refers to situations in which people (or other animals) experience failure at a given task, often numerous times. As a result of the repeated failure, they decide that the task cannot be completed successfully. People in this type of situation believe they are helpless and they stop trying – they "give up."

The concept of learned helplessness derives from experiments conducted in the late 1960s. In the original experiments, dogs were placed in harnesses so that they could not escape and then were presented with small electric shocks. Researchers then took the shocked dogs and some non-shocked dogs and placed them in a special box. The box was separated in the middle, and the floor on each side was designed to deliver electric shocks at the flick of a switch.



The researchers then electrified the side of the box where the dog was. They discovered that behaviour was distinctly different between the dogs who had originally been harnessed and shocked and those who had not. After being shocked in the box, the dogs that had not been harnessed and shocked almost immediately tried various methods of escape and ultimately jumped across the barrier to escape the pain. The dogs who had been previously harnessed and shocked showed distress (as did the other dogs), but unlike the other dogs, they simply lay down on the grid and whimpered in distress.

These experiments implied that previous learning had a detrimental effect on subsequent learning. The harnessed dogs that learned earlier they had no control over or ability to escape the pain were unable to escape the shocks in the box. Without this prior “learning” the non-shocked dogs were able to jump the barrier and escape the shock in every trial.

Psychologists performed similar experiments on other animals. Mice, for example, have a comparable nervous system to humans. If you put mice in a box and provide an escape route, they typically learn very rapidly to avoid a shock that occurs a few seconds after a bell sounds. If the escape route is blocked whenever the bell sounds and a new shock is administered, the mice will, in time, stop trying to run away. Later, even after the escape route is cleared, the mice will not try to flee even if they had successfully done so in the past.

Psychologists, like most researchers, like to perform experiments on human subjects to see if results obtained on lower animals reflect human behaviour. In one study exploring learned helplessness, researchers wanted to determine if similar behaviour to the dogs and mice would result if humans were subjected to uncomfortable stimuli. In the case of humans, however, an annoying noise was used instead of a shock. The results supported the idea that humans can learn to be helpless in an environment that actually offers control at a later date. This realization has since been applied to many aspects of psychology, and it has helped explain why people in certain circumstances accept their uncomfortable or negative situations despite the ability to change them. Research also indicates that learned helplessness is strongly correlated to depression.